

English Grammar Reference: Pronouns

Educational Series

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1 Definition

A **Pronoun** is a word used in place of a noun or a noun phrase to avoid repetition. The noun that a pronoun replaces is called its **antecedent**.

2 Classification of Pronouns

2.1 Personal Pronouns

These represent specific people or things. They change based on person, number, and case.

Person	Subjective	Objective	Possessive
1st (Singular)	I	me	mine
2nd (Singular)	you	you	yours
3rd (Singular)	he/she/it	him/her/it	his/hers/its
1st (Plural)	we	us	ours
2nd (Plural)	you	you	yours
3rd (Plural)	they	them	theirs

2.2 Demonstrative Pronouns

Used to point out specific objects.

- **Near in distance/time:** This (Singular), These (Plural).
- **Far in distance/time:** That (Singular), Those (Plural).

2.3 Relative Pronouns

Used to connect a clause or phrase to a noun or pronoun.

- **Who/Whom:** Used for people.
- **Which:** Used for animals and things.
- **That:** Used for people, animals, or things.
- **Whose:** Used to show possession.

2.4 Reflexive and Emphatic Pronouns

Words ending in *-self* or *-selves*.

- **Reflexive:** When the action of the verb returns to the subject (e.g., He hurt **himself**).
- **Emphatic:** Used to lay emphasis on the noun/pronoun (e.g., I will do it **myself**).

2.5 Indefinite Pronouns

Refer to people or things in a general way.

- **Examples:** Someone, anybody, everyone, nobody, none, all, some, few, many.

3 Important Rules of Usage

1. **Subject vs. Object Case:** Use subjective case after "than" or "as" when comparing (e.g., He is taller than **I**, not me).
2. **Order of Persons:** For good news/general statements, the order is 2-3-1 (You, he, and I). For mistakes/negative context, the order is 1-2-3 (I, you, and he).
3. **Each/Every/Either:** These are always followed by singular pronouns (e.g., Each of the boys has brought **his** book).
4. **Who vs. Whom:** "Who" acts as a subject; "Whom" acts as an object.

4 Common Errors

- **Incorrect:** It is me.
- **Correct:** It is **I**. (Use subjective case after "to be" verbs).
- **Incorrect:** One should do his duty.
- **Correct:** One should do **one's** duty.